Blushing Pilgrims

By Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota

INTRODUCTION

REBECCA: Romeo and Juliet has become mandatory reading in most high school English classes.
DIANE: Teachers use this classic tragedy to display brilliant prose, beautiful poetry and heightened style.
REBECCA: And yet, I think they're trying to teach us a little bit more…
DIANE: about life.
REBECCA: about love. (their eyes meet)
DIANE: Two classmatess explore the beauty of Shakespeare
REBECCA: and truly embody Romeo and Juliet in
BOTH: "Blushing Pilgrims"
DIANE: by Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

REBECCA: *(As Romeo, takes Diane's hand. Rebecca's reading is clear but she overly stresses the iambic pentameter.)* "If *I profane* with *my unworthiest hand* / This *holy shrine, (Diane giggles, shakes out her hand.)* the *gentle sin* is *this:* / My *lips,* two *blushing pilgrims, ready stand* to *smooth* that *rough* touch *with* a *tender kiss.* "

DIANE: *(As Juliet, stumbles through the speech, mispronouncing words.)* "Good pilgrim, you do ring your hand

REBECCA: "Wrong!"

DIANE: Huh?

REBECCA: "You do *wrong-not* ring-your hand too much."

DIANE: Oh, I thought you were saying I was wrong.

REBECCA: Well, yes, no. "Ring" not "wrong": The line is "You do *wrong* your hand too much."

DIANE: OK, OK. "Good pilgrim, you do wrong your hand too much." Excuse me!

REBECCA: Yes?

DIANE: What is that, "You do *wrong* your hand?" She saying he's using the wrong hand?

REBECCA: No. *Wrong* is a verb here. It means like "harm" or "insult." Juliet is telling Romeo that he shouldn't criticize his own hand just for touching her. That there's nothing wrong in that.

DIANE: So she's kind of a slut?

REBECCA: How can you say that?

DIANE: Well, she is. He's a player, and she's playing right into him.

REBECCA: This is the greatest love story in the English language. This is the story that sets the bar for every other love story ever written.

DIANE: Hardly. Have you seen *Pretty Woman?* Now that's a classic. Julia Roberts!

REBECCA: But she was a prostitute.

DIANE: Yes, and then she meets Richard Gere, a ruthless, lonely millionaire, and he rescues her from a life of crime. And she rescues him through the power of love. And they both live happily ever after. I loved the shopping spree on Rodeo Drive.

REBECCA: Let's get back to work. I've gotta get to my French horn practice.

DIANE: Fine, fine. I'm just letting you know what I think.

REBECCA: I appreciate it.

DIANE: No, you don't, but that's OK.

REBECCA: Look, let's just get through this. I need my A, and I'm trying to make the best of it. I'm sorry Mr. Davis forced you to work with me.

DIANE: What you mean is you're sorry he put you with *me*. But that's OK. Let's get to it.

REBECCA: Take it from your line, "Good pilgrim."

DIANE: "Good pilgrim, you do wrong your hand"-If you're so smart, explain this

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

pilgrim business. It makes no sense to me.

REBECCA: Here we go again.

DIANE: Humor me.

REBECCA: *(Dryly.)* You know what pilgrims are, right?

DIANE: I may not be a "student scholar" and member of the debating team, but I'm not an idiot. I know about the Pilgrims, the *Mayflower*, the first Thanksgiving with the Indians. Eating food off of Mom's prized Noritake china after she sighs for several hours about how she is expected to bleed for her family, Dad drinking too much and yelling about the football game. Me bursting into hysterics when my brother threw a hot candied apple at my sister and managed to hit me smack in the face. It's not about love. It's about carb overload.

REBECCA: Ooh, I'm sorry. But not *those* Pilgrims. This is back in Italy during the Renaissance, the rebirth and flowering of classic civilization that had died with the fall of the Roman Empire. Pilgrims are spiritual travelers who go on long, holy trips-pilgrimages-to religious sites in order to show their devotion and thanks to God.

DIANE: Freaky, man.

REBECCA: Well it was a big deal back then. To trek to the Holy Land, make a pilgrimage. I mean, they didn't have Club Med, you know.

DIANE: Well, aren't you the smarty-pants.

REBECCA: It's like this experience-this meeting of the two young lovers-is so beautiful that it is like a *religious communion.*

DIANE: Now that is so creepy.

REBECCA: How come? What's creepy.

DIANE: OK, imagine this. You're at a party.

REBECCA: A masquerade party, in fact, where all the participants are in costumes and

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

with their faces hidden behind painted masks.

DIANE: Even worse. A total stranger dressed up as God-knowswhat starts slobbering all over your hand. What are you going to do? Start making jokes about pilgrims and saints?

REBECCA: Yeah, I kinda see what you mean. But that's because you're looking at it the wrong way. His face is hidden because he's a Montague, and it would be death to be caught at this party.

DIANE: I don't care if he's dressed up like the pope. You're gonna go up to Joe Player and say, "Beat it, perv!" And if that doesn't do it, you're gonna kick him in the 'nads. I don't know what this Shakespeare dude was thinking, but he sure didn't know women.

REBECCA: But I think there's a difference because this guy is *the* one.

DIANE: Yeah, and how do you know?

REBECCA: You just know. It's magic. It's true love.

DIANE: How come? He's got the right breath mint? You like the way his butt looks?

REBECCA: It's gotta be more than that. I mean, to live up to "true love."

DIANE: This play was written by a guy, right?

REBECCA: William Shakespeare, the greatest playwright and poet in the English language. Born April 1564, died 1616.

DIANE: And guys want one thing only, right? Sex.

REBECCA: Well, some guys. OK, all *high school* guys. But Shakespeare was out of school when he wrote this.

DIANE: You watch TV right? Go to the movies? All guys want one thing.

REBECCA: Well, maybe.

DIANE: So what could be cooler to guys than a story where the gorgeous babe not only takes your line, but actually eggs you on to go further. Of course, with how sheltered they were back then, she was probably pretty desperate.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

REBECCA: *(Exasperated.)* Can we get back to work?

DIANE: OK. I'll say the words, but I think the play *sucks. (Laying on the sexiness.)* "Good pilgrim, you do wrong your hand too much, / Which mannerly devotion shows in this; / For saints have hands that pilgrims' hands do touch, / And palm to palm is holy palmers' kiss."

REBECCA: *(Seriously, but still with too much stress.)* "Have *not* saints *lips,* and *holy palmers too?*

DIANE: *(Even sexier.)* "Ay, pilgrim, lips that they must use in prayer."

REBECCA: Wait, hold!

DIANE: What? What? I'm doing what you asked-encouraging him!

REBECCA: Well, yeah, but there's a change here. Don't you see it?

DIANE: No.

REBECCA: OK. Romeo's trying to heat things up. He's got Juliet on the hand thing, so now he's working up to the lips.

DIANE: Right, I should have known.

REBECCA: But Juliet's blowing him off.

DIANE: Finally.

REBECCA: But nicely. She's like, pilgrims can touch hands, but they don't touch lips. Lips are for praying.

DIANE: Talk to the palm 'cause the lips ain't listening, girlfriend.

REBECCA: Exactly! Except that she's totally hooked. So while she wants to slow him down, she doesn't want to blow him off.

DIANE: You're really like *into* this Shakespeare, aren't you?

REBECCA: I guess. I hate to think that the greatest playwright of all time kind of sucks in his knowledge of love.

DIANE: Have you ever like really *been* in love?

REBECCA: *(Desperate.]* Can we *please* get to it!? I told you about my French horn

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

practice.

DIANE: How can you *act love* if you don't *know love?*

REBECCA: This is for English class! It doesn't matter! You just want to pronounce the words and look like you know what you're talking about.

DIANE: Being in love *doesn't matter?* When you're trying to act out the "greatest love story of all time"!?

REBECCA: Well, I've been very busy: studying, music lessons, forensics.

DIANE: Sounds boring.

REBECCA: I assure you, it isn't. I have big plans for my future, and I'm very focused.

DIANE: Kinda lonely, huh?

REBECCA: I'm concentrating on my career goals first.

DIANE: Now I get it!

REBECCA: What do you get?

DIANE: This "You do wring your hand too much"

REBECCA: "*Wrong* you hand."

DIANE: This is all you know about love!

REBECCA: This is so totally incorrect and unjust.

DIANE: Well, what do you know?

REBECCA: Jane Austen.

DIANE: Oh, we swing that way, do we? How twenty-first century!

REBECCA: No. She's an eighteenth-century British author, *Pride and Prejudice.*

DIANE: Oh. Eighteenth century, huh? That's a few years back. And she was well experienced in love?

REBECCA: Actually she lived and died in her father's house in a small village in England. Never married.

DIANE: So all you know about love comes from books and stuff, and one of your so-called experts is a dead virgin spinster!

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

REBECCA: I know more than what's in books! I've been around.

DIANE: Oh, have you?

REBECCA: Yeah.

DIANE: Have you ever been there in the clinch, where it's dark and you're alone with some guy and all you smell is his cologne and under that, the real smell of his sweat? *(Pause. Rebecca listens intently.)* And even though he's shaved all nicely, his face is a little rough against your skin, and he's clinging to you and trying to *unpeel* you, to get to you physically and mentally. And part of you knows you should stop him because he's just all worked up with testosterone, but part of you loves the feeling of his power and the feeling of your own power-that he wants and needs you so much. He wants to possess you, become you. And everything is sweaty and warm and smooth, his lips, his skin, his leather jacket.

REBECCA: Holy ...

DIANE: Oh, God. It *can* be a religious experience.

REBECCA: You're a poet.

DIANE: Nah, hardly. I just got carried away.

REBECCA: That's what poets do. They get carried away by *life,* and they take us along. That's what Shakespeare does. He knows love and life, and he serves it up on a silver platter, just like you did. Crap!

DIANE: What?

REBECCA: All I do is work and read and go to meetings. I get up early every morning, and run for a mile. I go to class and fix sandwiches for the homeless and tutor inner-city kids. And by the time I finish homework and practice and review my notes from the day, I just fall dead asleep.

DIANE: But when do you have time to shop, to get your makeup and nails done? *(Rebecca gestures to her plain style.)* Oh, I see. But at least people *respect*

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

you.

REBECCA: Like who? The only guy in my life is Pete Weiner, and he only likes me for my knowledge of baseball trivia and my collection of early computer games.

DIANE: Well, one day some real Romeo will come along, and he'll love you totally. Not just because he's all jazzed up and you're looking cute-but because he really knows *you* and that's who he wants to get inside and be a part of.

REBECCA: That's nice of you, Diane. But I know what I look like. I don't excite that kind of passion. But that's OK.

DIANE: You think because I got the nice butt and the boobs-?

REBECCA: Not *just* that. It's the whole quesadilla: the face, the bod, the spirit burning deep within you.

DIANE: Don't be so sure.

REBECCA: But you told me what it's like in the *clinch.* That passion, that intensity. I mean, I've never ...

DIANE: Well, sure-that's what it should be like, what it could be like. But usually ...

REBECCA: What usually?

DIANE: Usually it's midnight in somebody's crummy basement party. You're a little buzzed because the guy you really like is making out with some other girl. So you're with some loser who smells like pizza, and keeps saying, "You're hot, baby. You're really hot." And maybe you fool around a little because you get the stupid idea that it'll make the other one jealous. Until all at once, pepperoni breath goes to grab something he shouldn't, you dodge and he knocks over the potato chip dip in the metal bowl which falls onto the floor. The party givers' father suddenly screams from upstairs, "Everybody get out-now!"

REBECCA: Oh.

DIANE: Yeah.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

REBECCA: So maybe it could be worse than Pete Weiner.

DIANE: I guess. *(Imitating his loud, squeaky voice.)* But doesn't his voice kinda grate on your nerves like nails on a chalkboard?

REBECCA: He doesn't talk that much. I just wish he wanted to hold me and possess me, like you talked about. We mostly play Magic cards and computer simulation games. His new goal's to memorize enough digits of pi to make it into *Ripley's Believe It or Not.*

DIANE: Maybe his hormones haven't kicked in yet. Maybe you have to help him out.

REBECCA: What do you mean?

DIANE: Encourage him. You know like Juliet in the play.

REBECCA: Except my Romeo hasn't even made the first move yet.

DIANE: Yeah, some guys need a little help getting started. Just a signal or two.

REBECCA: I never thought of that.

DIANE: Girls have to be sharp.

REBECCA: Yeah, they do. Thanks.

DIANE: My pleasure. It's not very often that anyone thinks I have anything to teach.

REBECCA: Are you kidding? Your life is like a novel. Full of passion and heartache.

DIANE: I'm surprised to say it, but it'll happen to you one day.

REBECCA: You think?

DIANE: Yeah, you don't show it off, but you have something inside.

REBECCA: You really think it could happen?

DIANE: Sure. But it wouldn't hurt if you did something with your hair and wore lipstick.

REBECCA: Hey, I have an idea.

DIANE: What?

REBECCA: Let's switch places.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DIANE: You want to start cheerleading and have me join the debating team?

REBECCA: Nah. You be Romeo. I want to try Juliet.

DIANE: OK. Actually, I think I *get* this Romeo dude. *(She positions herself and takes Rebecca's hand. While she still stumbles over the occasional word, her reading is spot on. She has Romeo's quiet intensity.)* "If I profane with my unworthiest hand / This holy shrine, the gentle sin is this: / My lips, two blushing pilgrims, ready stand to smooth that rough touch with a tender kiss."

REBECCA: *(Takes Diane's hand and holds it tenderly. She speaks normally, without the exaggerated stresses.)* "Good pilgrim, you do wrong your hand too much, / Which mannerly devotion shows in this; / For saints have hands that pilgrims' hands do touch, / And palm to palm is holy palmers' kiss."

DIANE: "Have not saint lips, and holy palmers too?"

REBECCA: "Ay, pilgrim, lips that they must use in prayer."

DIANE: "0 then, dear saint, let lips do what hands do. / They pray; grant thou, lest faith turn to despair."

REBECCA: "Saints do not move, though grant for prayers' sake."

DIANE: "Then move not while my prayer's effect I take."

REBECCA: *(Looking at the book.)* It says here that Romeo kisses- *(Diane kisses Rebecca.)*

REBECCA: Oh. *(Pause. Quietly.)* So that's how it's supposed to be.

DIANE: We *are* pretty good actors, huh?

REBECCA: *(Not what she meant.)* Yeah, yeah.

DIANE: And that Shakespeare ain't completely bogus either.

REBECCA: Do you think it ever goes like that in real life? I mean the kiss? Love?

DIANE: I don't know. I really don't. But I bet you get your A.

REBECCA: Not that grades are everything.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

DIANE: You're right.

REBECCA: Hey! What do you say about a hamburger break?

DIANE: Sure, I'm starved, but I thought you had music practice?

REBECCA: Yeah, but I think there's time for everything. *(Smiling.)* What do you say, *good pilgrim?*

DIANE: *(Puts her arm through Rebecca's.}* Let's *motor-dear saint.*

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ira Brodsky and Barbara Lhota
Book: Duo Practice and Competition: 35 8-10 Minute Original Comedic Plays for Two Females
ISBN: 978-1575253800
Publisher: Smith & Kraus
Date (Month/Year): September 2004

AWARD HISTORY

MN State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY